UX RESEARCH CASE STUDY

A Pricing Question That Was Not About Price

An executive-mandated discovery into how Thryv shows proof of value, which found a product delivering value that customers had no way to see



Purchase
Bought expecting leads

Onboarding
Presence being built, not leads

Months 2 to 3
Value questioned, cancellation

Archive review · CSM in-depth interview · CSM workshop · Lead researcher · July 2026

The study at a glance

The executive team asked how to justify Thryv's pricing. The research moved the conversation off price entirely.

6

findings that held across both primary studies and the archive review

2 to 3

months in, customers who expected leads question the value and cancel, even when the product is working as designed

6

activation moments CSMs named independently, discovered by accident rather than by design

4+3

recommended actions, plus three investigations that became the forward research agenda

What the study settled. The product was delivering value. What was missing was any mechanism by which a customer could see it happening. That turns a pricing problem into a visibility problem, and the two have completely different solutions.

01

The question that came down

An ask from the executive team, with a default answer already sitting inside it

The ask, and the answer built into it

Thryv wanted to know how we might show proof of value to our customers. Behind that sat two commercial problems the executives named directly: justify the pricing, and make Thryv appealing enough to hold the customers we had and attract groups we did not yet have.

The default answer

If customers are not convinced the product is worth the price, the obvious moves are to argue the price down, bundle more in, or build a better pitch.

Every one of those treats the problem as a communication problem on the sales side of the relationship.

What I designed for instead

I did not think that was the problem, but I did not have the evidence to say so yet, and a study designed to confirm what I already suspected would not have been worth running.

So I built the work to be able to come back and say the executives had framed it correctly, if that was what the data showed.

Retention and acquisition, with price as the pressure point. A question framed that way carries its own answer. The first job was making sure that answer could survive being tested.

02

How I approached it

Read everything we already held, then go to the people who watch the whole arc

Starting with what we already had

Before recruiting anyone I went through the research we already held. Five to ten prior studies touched on customer expectations, product adoption or value perception in some form, none of them designed for this question.

1

This was the first real test of the research operations work

A taxonomy and a shared knowledge base are only worth the effort if someone can walk up to them with a new question and find the relevant prior work without already knowing it exists. I could, which is the only reason a review like this fit inside the timeline at all.

2

The archive gave me a pattern rather than answers

Across studies run for unrelated reasons, customers kept describing a gap between what they thought they had bought and what they had actually bought.

3

Nobody had written it down as a finding

In each individual study it was a side observation. Seen together it was the shape of something, and it was enough to justify going out and testing it properly.

Reading across studies built for other purposes is a good way to generate a hypothesis and a poor way to confirm one. I treated the archive review as the former.

Why I talked to CSMs rather than customers

The fastest path would have been to survey customers about perceived value. I chose not to.

Customers are poor witnesses to their own expectation gaps

Someone who bought a product expecting one thing and received another will usually report dissatisfaction, not the mechanics of how the mismatch happened. And the customers whose experience mattered most, the ones who cancelled at month two or three, were the hardest to reach and the least motivated to talk.

CSMs sit in the one position that sees the whole arc, start to finish

They are on calls with these customers daily, from the first onboarding conversation through the moment someone decides to leave, across hundreds of accounts rather than one. They watch the expectation gap form in real time and spend their working hours trying to close it.

Study one: in-depth CSM interview

July 2026. Went deep on one CSM's full account history, from onboarding through cancellation.

Study two: CSM workshop on onboarding

Second quarter of the fiscal year. Let a group rank friction points against each other, which is how the largest one surfaced.

The tradeoff is real. CSMs are an exceptionally well-placed proxy, and they are still not the customer.

03

What came back

Six findings that held across both studies, and six moments that reliably land

The gap between what was bought and what was sold

Customers expect leads. Marketing Center builds presence.

Most customers buy to get on Google or generate leads, and arrive expecting a fast rise in inbound calls. What the product does is build online presence, the foundation that supports lead generation over time.

By months two to three, customers who have not seen leads start cancelling, even when the product is working exactly as designed.

Listings and leads are not the same thing.

Listings management keeps a business's information consistent across directories and Google. Leads are a downstream outcome depending on a great deal more. CSMs spend significant call time correcting the framing.

The workshop ranked this the top friction point, above everything else on the table.

There is a self-service gap nobody had set expectations for.

The product performs only when customers feed it: connected social accounts, accurate listings data, responded reviews, uploaded photos. Many arrive expecting Thryv to do that work.

At this price point full management is not viable, which makes early expectation setting the only lever available.

A product performing to specification was losing customers. Which means the failure was not in the product's performance, but in what the customer had been led to expect of it.

What determines whether value lands

Tech-savviness predicts how much value a customer sees.

One of the strongest predictors in the whole dataset. Non-technical customers, the current majority, struggle past basic setup and rarely return to deeper features on their own, even when visibly impressed during a demo.

The ideal customer profile we were selling into skewed toward the segment that benefits least.

Trust is the bridge to value, and it breaks quietly.

Customers engage only when they trust both the product and the person supporting it. Trust breaks when our own integrations cause a problem on the customer's behalf, or when a technical issue creates more work than doing the job by hand.

When it breaks, customers disengage without warning, so the usual escalation signals never fire.

Customers think Marketing Center is Google listings, and that is it.

Social posting, AI review responses, heatmaps, competitor tracking, call analytics and AI call scoring are effectively invisible until a CSM walks someone through them.

The reaction when that happens is real and consistent, but it depends entirely on how much effort an individual CSM puts in.

Value delivery was not built into the product. It was built into the staff, which means it scaled with individual effort rather than with the business.

In their words

Customer success managers, on what they watch happen across hundreds of accounts

> *“This is not a leads tool. This is not a leads product. If they are not getting the leads they are looking for, they will cancel, even with heavy usage of social.”*

> *“You do not purchase QuickBooks just hoping it will do your taxes. Thryv is the same way: it does not deliver results if you do not give it the data it needs.”*

> *“Are they impressed? Yes. Are they using it after the first show? Not all the time.”*

> *“I have never heard of anyone being sold on the full platform. It is still mostly being sold for online presence.”*

A fifth, on how trust fails: if the technical issue takes too long, you lose their buy-in. They say: this is creating more work. I am done.

The moments that actually land

CSMs could name, specifically and consistently, which features produce a reaction when a customer is shown them for the first time.

Listings everywhere

Update business information once and watch it appear across every directory.

AI review responses

Drafted replies to Google reviews with search optimization built in. Non-technical customers adopt them readily.

The first tracked call

Shows a customer exactly where a lead came from, which nothing else in the product does.

Heatmap intel

Page-level click data surfacing issues they would never have found on their own.

Multi-channel social

Post to every channel at once, with AI-generated captions.

AI call scoring

Scored calls, which show the platform doing something more intelligent than managing a listing.

Six moments, named independently by people who had watched them land hundreds of times. They were being discovered by accident. That is the difference between an activation strategy and good luck.

04

The reframe

The executives had asked how to justify the price. Justification was the wrong verb.

From a pricing problem to a visibility problem

What was true

The product was delivering value. Listings were being corrected across directories, reviews were being answered, presence was being built.

The delivery was not in doubt.

What was missing

A small business owner two months in had no way to look at Thryv and answer the question “what has this done for me.”

In the absence of an answer they supplied their own, which was the one they had arrived with: I was promised leads and I do not have leads.

You cannot argue someone into perceiving value they cannot observe.

Price is only ever evaluated against perceived value, so the lever is not the number on the invoice. A pricing problem and a visibility problem have completely different solutions, and the organization had been resourcing the wrong one.

Four recommended actions

1

Set out the two roles explicitly

Thryv's role and the customer's role, from first contact, through sales messaging and onboarding materials, so the shared responsibility is established before the first CSM call rather than discovered at month three.

2

Engineer the activation moments in

Build the six moments into onboarding as structured product milestones, surfaced in-product with context on what just happened and why it matters commercially.

3

Build segmented onboarding paths

From tech-savviness captured at signup, because non-technical and tech-savvy customers plainly need different journeys through the same product.

4

Market the full platform

Position Marketing Center as the platform it is rather than the listings tool customers believe they are buying, so the expectation gap narrows before anyone signs.

Three of the four are expectation work. Only one of them touches the product itself, which is what you would expect if the problem is perception rather than performance.

Three investigations, and why the middle one mattered

This is where a one-off study turned into a program.

Is the value visible at all?

Establish whether the value Thryv delivers is currently visible to customers, and whether our existing reporting surfaces communicate it or whether seeing it depends on a CSM being there to interpret.

What can we credibly claim?

Define the value we can accurately claim, grounded in data, separating what the product delivers on its own from what is co-created with the customer's effort.

How do we make it tangible?

Explore how to make value visible across the whole customer journey rather than in one product area: in-product reporting, milestone moments, and how return is communicated.

I was deliberate about the order. There is a version of this work that goes straight to building a dashboard full of encouraging numbers, and it fails the moment a customer checks a claim we cannot support. Defining what we can honestly say had to come before deciding how to say it.

05

What it changed

And what I would do differently if I ran it again

What it changed

The strategic conversation moved off price and onto reporting.

1

Leadership accepted the redirection

They came away persuaded that the highest-leverage work was making Thryv's impact on a customer's business legible to that customer, rather than building a better argument for the price.

2

The shape of the answer became reporting

Lead counts customers can see, a business health score that tells them where they stand, revenue change they can attribute. A running answer to what this has done for me, available without a CSM present to interpret it.

3

The three investigations became the agenda

They became the forward research program for the value question rather than remaining a closing slide, and the work was underway when I left Thryv in November.

That is a different place to spend engineering effort than where the question started. I am describing a change in direction and in what the organization believed the problem was, because that is what I can evidence. I am not claiming shipped features I did not stay to see.

What I would do differently

Limitations I put in the report

- Everything here is CSM-reported. They are an unusually good proxy, with breadth across hundreds of accounts, and they are still filtering through their own memory, incentives and theories about why accounts churn.
- The cancellation pattern at months two to three is a pattern CSMs observe, not one I measured.
- One in-depth interview and one workshop is enough to establish that a pattern exists and nothing like enough to size it.
- No behavioral or account data ran alongside it. Activation events, ticket volume, feature usage and real churn timing all exist inside the company.
- Tech-savviness was the strongest predictor and the least rigorously established. It is a CSM judgment applied after the fact, vulnerable to being assigned retrospectively to customers who did not succeed.

What I would change

- Get to churned customers. The people who cancelled at month three hold the most direct evidence about the expectation gap, and they are absent from this study entirely.
- Pair the qualitative work with account data from the start rather than treating it as a later phase. Sizing a pattern is what turns a finding into a business case.
- Measure tech-savviness rather than infer it, capturing it at signup and testing it against outcomes, which would also give the segmented onboarding recommendation its evidence base.
- Design a test for the activation moments before recommending them. Six features that reliably impress in a demo are not necessarily six features that change retention.